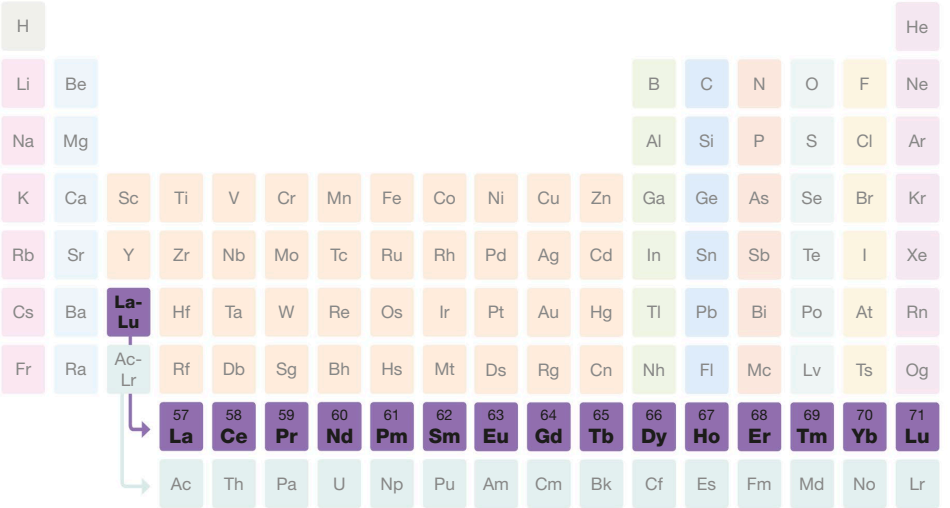

Lanthanides

The metals in this series are relatively common on Earth – and very useful in technology – but notoriously difficult to separate from one another. Here, a sliver of lanthanum nitrate, showing off a rainbow of colours under a microscope, has been extracted from a complex mineral filled with many other lanthanides.